[embezzlement] and, when a commissioner came down to make enquiries, committed suicide.'

Dig deeper still and you find that on being appointed Collector, Rous Peter began to draw freely on the government's purse as if it were his own. He built himself a palatial bungalow and lived the life of a prince, so much so that by 1819 he was in such a financial pickle that he asked his accountant to take what was left in the government treasury and use it to speculate, resulting in even greater losses. He then wrote out a statement apologising to the EICo for what he had done, which he placed in a sealed envelope marked 'Not to be opened till my death', apparently contemplating suicide. In the event another nine years passed before Peter's death, by his own hand, on 6 August 1828.

In the inquiry that followed it was discovered that Peter had squandered away huge sums of government money 'to the amount of between £70,000 and £100,000' – somewhere in the region of £5 million to £8 million by today's reckoning. Five members of his staff were imprisoned, and his estate, including a great many jewels, was sold to pay off part of the debt. 'So ended a life of extortion, cruelty and immorality by suicide,' noted a contemporary who got caught up in the scandal.[2]

So here are two accounts of the same man: one familiar to hundreds of thousands of devotees of the goddess Meenakshi and to readers of Wikipedia; the other virtually unknown except to the few who have checked the facts.

These include the fact that throughout the EICo's Madras Presidency local administrators in the form of commissioners, collectors and magistrates presented gifts to the temple deities at major festivals in the name of the *Sircar* (government), often in the form of shawls, a tradition derived from the Muslim custom of rulers presenting *khilat*, or robes of honour. These same administrators also